insisted that they first become members of the Indian National Congress. Nehru also endorsed a large-scale outreach campaign that sought to bring Muslims into the Congress by promising to better their economic conditions. This move ignited further counterefforts from the League to reach out and rally Muslim voters behind their party. It is in this context that Nehru engaged in a brief exchange of letters with Jinnah directly.

In full awareness that the Congress did not require the League to rule, Nehru conducted this communication from a position of strength. Jinnah refused to acknowledge that the election result was an adequate measure of the political value of the Muslim League. To him, the communal question remained the most critical issue to determine India's future. Jinnah's cold responses were his way to shake Nehru out of this false sense of security that the
Hindu-Muslim issue had receded into the background and given way to lofty ideas around socialism and constitutional democracy. Perhaps for this reason, Jinnah refused to lay the Muslim case to Nehru anew.

NEHRU-JINNAH EXCHANGE, 1938

(As reprinted in S.S. Peerzada (ed.), (1944), *Leaders' Correspondence with Mr. Jinnah*, Bombay, India: S.H. Nazir Ahmad, pp. 77–136.)

Nehru to Jinnah – 18 January 1938

Lucknow,

18 January 1938

Dear Mr Jinnah,

I have read the statement you issued recently to the press with care. I am afraid we approach the question from differing viewpoints and I feel that your approach is not very helpful. But I entirely agree with you that an argument carried on through the medium of the press is not desirable. Indeed I had decided not to issue press statements on the subject, but after